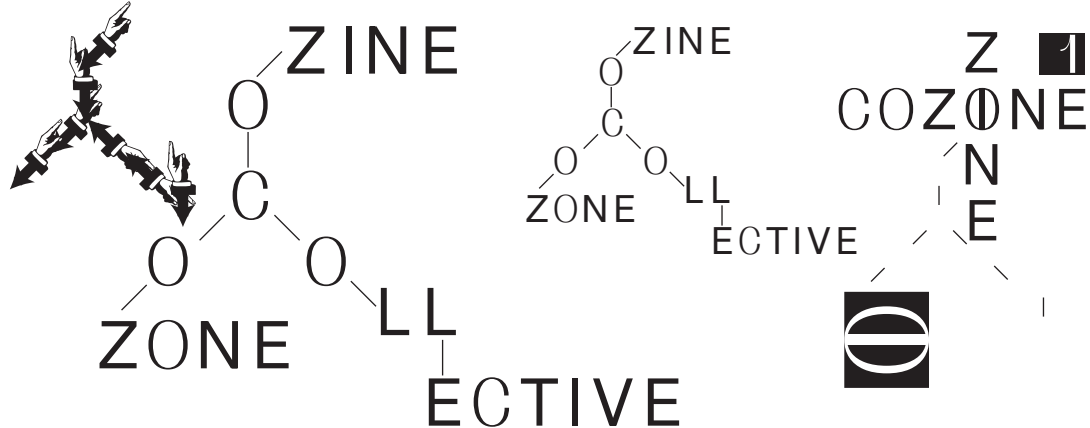


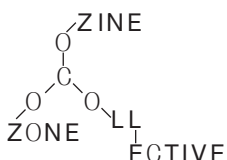


semiotics
semiotics
Fascism

The idea of this Zine series is to explore subjects in our sociologic, philosophic, artistic and political context. By us we mean the plurality of bodies and names we gather and try to interconnect //situated, material, affected, and affective. Producing a form of critic through what we are experiencing as individuals and communities, through lived conditions, gestures, languages, and shared spaces. CoZine is a product from the CoZone collective, still emerging from those reflexions we wish to expand.

Co as community, collective, situated in an area that we try to define each time we're dealing with our chosen subjects. We welcome all feedbacks or reviews related to this production, and are always willing to include participants in our next Zines.

We are excited to share with you our first edition of CoZine! For edition_01, we decided to go through the subject of Semiotics & Semantics on Fascism.



What Is Where

The great wall of “FÜHRERS”

Kaz Mose.....p. 4

The Semantic Fascist Apparatus of Trump’s DEI Policies

Azur Schleinitzp.14

Redacted Redacted Redacted:

Language, Territory and the Self

oumaima.....p. 25

CoZone.....p. 35



The great wall of “FÜHRERS”

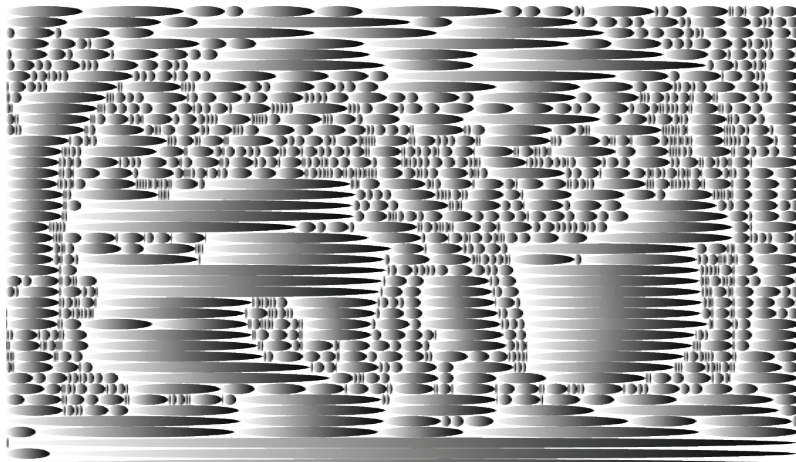


1. While conventional archaeological consensus posits that the Great Wall of China was constructed primarily as a defensive fortification against northern incursions, Franz Kafka offers a divergent perspective in his short story, The Great Wall of China. Kafka interrogates the strategic utility of the structure, asking, "How can protection be provided by a wall which is not built continuously?"¹ He suggests that a discontinuous wall fails to offer physical security and, ironically, exposes the structure itself to destruction by nomadic groups. Kafka posits that the nomads, described as moving with the speed of "grasshoppers," possessed a superior vantage point of the construction process compared to the builders themselves. Regardless of the text's historiographical accuracy, Kafka's analysis illuminates a pattern of authority and power that remains highly relevant to modern political theory.

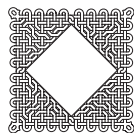
Kafka elucidates a mechanism of control wherein the process of eternal construction sustains the imperial system, Rather than the finished product.



This is achieved through two primary vectors:
the cultivation of paranoia regarding
"northern impurities" and the mobilization of
the labor force around a project of infinite
duration.

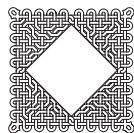


This dynamic serves as a
potent allegory for the
mechanics of contemporary
fascism. Fascist
ideologies consistently
emerge by invoking a
mythologized, glorious
past—whether Mussolini's
Roman Empire, the Islamist
concept of the Caliphate,
or the irredentist
narratives of "Greater
Israel"—contrasted against
a present "impurity" that
allegedly disrupts this
romanticized image.



Consequently, the "eternal wall" finds its modern manifestation in the perpetual wars of neo-fascism and the systemic purging of minorities. These political projects rely on the fabrication of an eternal enemy to maintain hegemonic control.

From the specific vantage point of the Iranian diaspora—having fled theocratic authoritarianism only to witness the resurgence of far-right nationalism in the West—a comparative analysis reveals a striking convergence. Despite the semiotic differences between Eastern theocratic fascism and Western secular nationalism (which often appear as photographic negatives of one another),

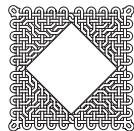


Both systems operate upon the same foundational mechanism identified by Kafka: The consolidation of power through institutionalized paranoia and the obsession with a never-ending defense against the "others."

2. Building on Kafka's allegory of the Wall as a mechanism of perpetual construction and institutionalized paranoia, the metaphor can be extended beyond the fascist war machine to the functioning of the state apparatus itself.



As Deleuze and Guattari argue, fascism is structurally paradoxical: it operates through the state while simultaneously being animated by a war machine that escapes, exceeds, and over codes state logic. This internal contradiction accounts for fascism's volatility. Fascist regimes exalt discipline, unity, and order, yet at the same time they generate uncontrolled violence, paranoia, and tendencies toward annihilation.

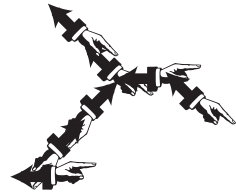
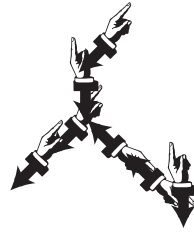


Although fascism emerges from capitalist conditions, it does not replicate capitalism's operative logic. Capitalism functions through the decoding of flows—of money, labor, and desire—whereas fascism responds to this instability by forcibly recoding these flows into fixed categories of identity, race, nation, and destiny. Through this process of reterritorialization, imaginary walls of segregation are erected within the fascist state apparatus itself. These walls are not merely symbolic but function materially to organize bodies, regulate movement, and delimit belonging.

Crucially, there is no universal or stable formula for fascist segregation. Historical evidence demonstrates that such exclusions manifest differently across societies, even within the same temporal frame. The life of Essad Bey (1905–1942) provides a revealing case study. Bey—a Muslim writer of Jewish origin and a sympathizer of fascist ideology—was nevertheless forced to leave Germany in 1938 and seek refuge in Fascist Italy.



This displacement underscores significant divergences in how antisemitism operated within German and Italian fascism. Whereas Nazi Germany constructed its exclusionary “wall” around a biologically grounded obsession with racial purity, Italian Fascism articulated exclusion more through a culturally defined notion of purity. These distinctions illustrate the adaptive, context-specific nature of fascist paranoia and segregation.

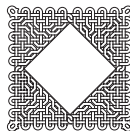


This structural logic persists in contemporary manifestations of fascist and proto-fascist politics, despite their ideological and semiotic differences. Zionist political projects, neo-fascist movements in Germany, ISIS, the Islamic Republic of Iran, as well as state



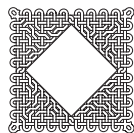
formations such as the United States or the Russian Federation, each construct distinct myths of supremacy. Yet despite their divergent narratives, they operate through a shared mechanism: the production of an internal or external enemy and the erection of ideological walls that enable continuous mobilization. Fascism, therefore, is not fundamentally a matter of symbols or signs—nor has it ever been. Just as the Great Wall of China functioned less as a defensive structure than as a means for sustaining imperial control through perpetual construction, Contemporary fascist and semiotic-theological walls—whether secular or divine—serve to sustain imperial war machines and state apparatuses.

3. Having established the relationship between the allegory of the Great Wall, the fascist war machine, and the state apparatus, it is necessary to address an additional layer of fascism that engages the allegory of the wall in a fundamentally different way: micro fascism. This dimension operates not at the molar scale of empire and state power, but at the molecular level of subjectivity, everyday life, and internalized authority. In *The Trial*, Kafka embeds the parable “Before the Law,” a text that can be read as bearing a concealed yet significant relation to The Great Wall of China.



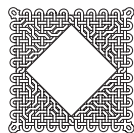
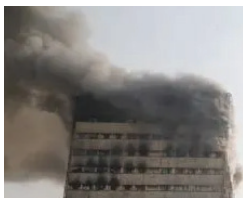
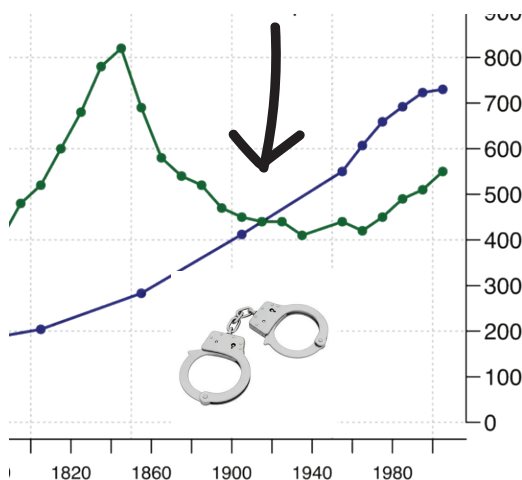
However, this relation does not unfold at the level of imperial infrastructure or administrative power; rather, it emerges at the scale of the subject positioned before authority. The parable recounts the story of a man who spends his entire life waiting before a gate that leads to the Law. At the moment of his death, he questions the gatekeeper, asking why, despite the universal striving toward the Law, no one else has ever sought entry through this gate.

The gatekeeper responds that this entrance was intended solely for him and that it will now be closed. This narrative crystallizes a central mechanism of fascism that persists across divergent semiotic systems and ideological myths. Fascism does not operate exclusively at the level of the state or through overt political structures; it is sustained by a deeply internalized, paranoid logic that permeates everyday life. The gate of the Law functions as an opening in the wall that cuts through the lived experience of subjects, organizing their relation to authority, legitimacy, and belonging.



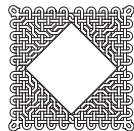
For individuals who have experienced immigration or other forms of radical transition, this mechanism becomes particularly visible. There exists a moment in which the body is temporarily severed from documentation, legal recognition, or symbolic inscription—a moment in which the subject stands exposed before the gate of the Law. Although this moment may be temporally brief, it offers a critical rupture through which the broader condition of life spent waiting before this gate becomes perceptible. Even when legal representation is eventually restored—if it is restored at all—the relationship between the body and the wall of the state apparatus is irreversibly altered.

**THERE EXISTS A MOMENT
IN WHICH THE BODY IS
TEMPORARILY SEVERED**



The encounter with the Law as an inaccessible threshold produces a lasting transformation in how authority is perceived and inhabited. It is within this context that fascism's persistent targeting of queer subjects and immigrants must be understood. Fascist formations depend upon the imposition of destiny and identity upon bodies, demanding that life conform to predetermined narratives of origin, purity, and function. Importantly, the concept of the Law invoked here cannot be reduced to formal legal systems alone. Rather, it encompasses a broader network of codes—language, history, theology, and metaphysical notions of fate—that operate as mechanisms of inscription upon the flesh. At this depth, the wall of fascist mythology reveals itself as inseparable from semiotic regimes that naturalize domination and exclusion. The gate between the Law and the body thus remains permanently guarded. It exists not to be passed through, but to sustain waiting, obedience, and self-regulation. Embedded within the wall and protected by its gatekeepers, this threshold feeds upon the obsessions and paranoias of the state apparatus, ensuring that subjects internalize the very barriers that confine them.

Winter - 2025 - Brussels



Sources

1. Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. 1983. *Anti-Oedipus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*. Translated by Robert Hurley, Mark Seem, and Helen R. Lane. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
2. Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. 1987. *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*. Translated by Brian Massumi. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
3. Kafka, Franz. 1998. *The Trial*. Translated by Breon Mitchell. New York: Schocken Books.
4. Kafka, Franz. 2007. "The Great Wall of China." In *The Complete Stories*, edited by Nahum N. Glatzer, translated by Willa and Edwin Muir, 236–246. New York: Schocken Books.
5. Kafka, Franz. 2007. "Before the Law." In *The Complete Stories*, edited by Nahum N. Glatzer, translated by Willa and Edwin Muir, 3–4. New York: Schocken Books.

Font used: Andalé Mono by Monotype Imaging, Inc

The Semantic Fascist Apparatus of Trump's DEI Policies

On February 25, 2025, a new memorandum¹ was sent to the United States federal government institutions. Signed by Sean Parnell, the Assistant to the Secretary of Defense for Public Affairs, it stipulates a list of words that the federal agencies need to get rid of. This list of words is related to Joe Biden's last mandate regarding DEI policy: Diversity, Equity and Inclusion.

To contextualise, the DEI Program began with the Civil Rights Act of 1964, and has been built up through federal administrations following social unrests in the United States. The DEI program aimed to oversee the distribution of resources and opportunities for discriminatory groups: to counter racism, gender inequalities, etc. As Alexandra Olson says : « It's not a specific policy. It is an idea that you want to make your workplace or your school or any number of institutions inclusive and diverse and welcoming to a diverse population. »²



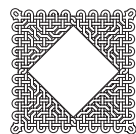
The Stonewall Inn, New York



During his presidency, Joe Biden has tried to make DEI policies more effective so it could be applied as well to private employment policies, agricultural decisions. The Trump Administration decided few months after Donald Trump's reelection to get rid of more than 350 words present in texts and images from US government databases. The result of this policy is taking many faces: for instance, the US army has suppressed from their archives a lot of pictures of black people and women military. Another concern of this executive order takes place within federal research grants. To apply now implies not using those words which means that « amid the uncertainty, some scientists (.) are considering self-censoring themselves to improve their chances of receiving grants. »³. Even broad/umbrella words like « cancer » are part of this list, which make a global confusion on what Trump's Administration wants to target in this measure.

Several photos of an Army Corps of Engineers dredging project in California were marked for deletion, apparently because a local engineer in the photo had the last name Gay. And a photo of Army Corps biologists was on the list, seemingly because it mentioned they were recording data about fish — including their weight, size, hatchery and gender.

I would like to take this example of erasing words from governmental institutions to reflect on fascist politics of semantics, as a way to get control of the productive apparatus of knowledge. In this text, I will center my reflection on the LGBTQIA+ words that Trump decided to erase. He did not focus on those ones more than others. Racism, Climate change, a sort of reversed intersectionality could encompass this list; but here I will develop this reflection regarding the gender and sexual minorities.

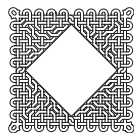


Semantics is the meaning we put into words, their subtleties, the way we can play with them. But if we erase words, then where do we place the meaning of our actions and feelings? Where can representation stand? The most famous example of this DEI executive order is the picture of the aircraft « Enola Gay » which has been removed from US Army archives. This picture is in no way related to some homosexual representation, the name Enola Gay refers to the pilot's mother of the aircraft. But the fact that it is written GAY on the bomber led to the obliteration of the picture of the US army data base. What is alarming as well, is that this specific bomber aircraft is the one that dropped the atomic bomb on Hiroshima. Erasing this data is then also related to avoid a part of US responsibility in a civilian massacre. It brings up the whole question of the deed of remembrance. But let's leave that question here for now.

In the title of this article, I use the term fascism⁴, my goal is not to give a definition of it, which is something way too complex to elaborate in a few lines, but rather to try to point out specific strategies that are being part of the fascist apparatus: the ones related to fascists semiotics. Semiotic is what is meant through signs and words, so here the semiotic would be the action of erasing some vocabulary, which leads to a cancelation of producing knowledge.

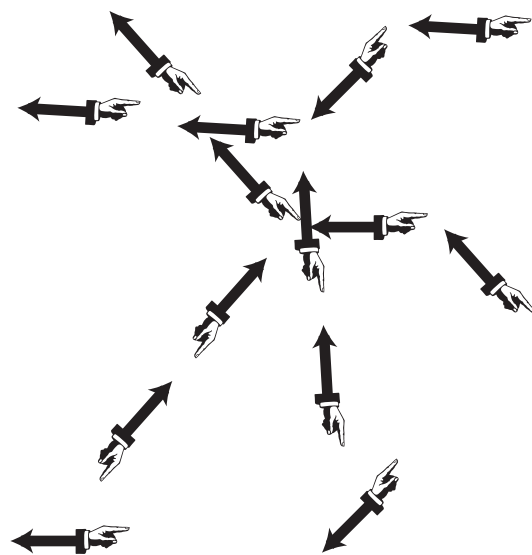
I will use some of the 14 points Umberto Eco declined in his *Eternal Fascism* text to refer to a form of a definition of fascism and show how Trump's new DEI policy can be a witness of contemporary fascist strategy, disguised by bewildered discourses.

In *Ur-Fascism*⁵, Umberto Eco mentions 14 traits that characterise what could be the « universal form of fascism ». He develops fascism as a synecdoche, a word that is used now to encompass a whole of totalitarian regimes, despite its Italian origin specific to Mussolini's totalitarian government.

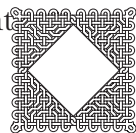


Those 14 traits make a stance to what would be common to each « fascist » regime. One of the points he elaborates on is the « Fear Of Difference ». It comes out of the construction of an « Other » to define and solidify in-group identity. This idea of construction of an « Other » is quite common and we can relate it to each discriminated group that is being targeted within our western societies. But within Trump's policy it takes another perspective. Donald Trump legitimates his move of suppressing some DEI words because for him, « the Other » constructed group (which we can relate to all the discriminated group struggling within ultraliberal system), threatens white straight men: « to investigate private companies pursuing training and hiring practices that conservative critics consider discriminatory against non-minority groups. »⁶ By claiming this, it kinds of reverses Eco's logic about the construction of the « other ».

The « other » is the group that permit the « non-other » groups to have a feeling of belonging to something, which in fascism can be for instance the nation. But if the group on top of the capitalist hierarchy becomes « the other » (the group which is threatened) reclaimed by the main man of power in a country, the confusion is spreading. This strategy could be based on the victim/oppressor dialectic that helps Donald Trump to blur paths on who to blame, and who could merit to be part of the in-group identity.



Moreover, Trump erased all the words that allow the « other » group to identify to each other, constructed on the fear of difference. It leads then to a paradox enhanced by the miss of this vocabulary that plays an assignment role, due to its obliteration.



This leads me to another point of Eco's Ur-Fascism: « All the Nazi or Fascist schoolbooks made use of an impoverished vocabulary, and an elementary syntax, in order to limit the instruments for complex and critical reasoning. » ⁷ He underlines the importance of semantics and vocabulary within fascist strategies of getting control out of knowledge. If we erase a part of our own identification, part of our individualities, what constructs us, then how can we reclaim rights or equity? How can we be accepted?

This is one of the biggest danger due to fascist dialectics: it intends to perceive individuals like they « have no rights, and the People is conceived as a quality, a monolithic entity expressing the Common Will. »

It appears quite as a contemporary paradox within western societies because capitalism lets individuals mirror a cult of themselves where the concept of meritocracy and the pyramidal structure of bureaucracy could be some example. But those individualities are not part of cultural nor social groups. Capitalism enhances an individuality that rhymes with loneliness (loneliness here defined as exclusion an isolation), and in that way joins Eco's idea of people seen as a quality, a benefit to take from, rather than active/thoughtful subjects whom interact and share experiences. In that way, Trump's DEI cancelling impeaches people to refer themselves to some words, therefore some grounded mutualities, that allow people to gather and reflect not only on themselves, but also on their relatives. It goes hand in hand with the importance of representation. The LGBTQIA+ community has struggled (and is still struggling) a lot to get out of the mis-, or un- representation they faced within cultural and social contexts. The Stonewall movement in the 60s for example which has been stated as a national monument in 2016 under Obama's presidency has been targeted by Trump EO's: the transgender mention does not exist anymore on the website, only the LGB acronym remains. It is highly symbolic since the Stonewall monument is « the country's first national monument dedicated to lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender history. » ⁸



1. accessible
2. activism
3. activists
4. advocacy
5. advocate
6. advocates
7. affirming care
8. all-inclusive
9. allyship
10. anti-racism
11. antiracist
12. assigned at birth
13. assigned female at birth
14. assigned male at birth
15. at risk
16. barrier
17. barriers
18. belong
19. bias
20. biased
21. biased toward
22. biases
23. biases towards
24. biologically female
25. biologically male
26. BIPOC
27. Black
28. breastfeed + people
29. breastfeed + person
30. chestfeed + people
31. chestfeed + person
32. clean energy
33. climate crisis
34. climate science
35. commercial sex worker
36. community diversity
37. community equity
38. confirmation bias
39. cultural competence
40. cultural differences
41. cultural heritage
42. cultural sensitivity
43. culturally appropriate
44. culturally responsive
45. DEI
46. DEIA
47. DEIAB
48. DEIJ
49. disabilities
50. disability
51. discriminated
52. discrimination
53. discriminatory
54. disparity
55. diverse
56. diverse backgrounds
57. diverse communities
58. diverse community
59. diverse group
60. diverse groups
61. diversified
62. diversify
63. diversifying
64. diversity
65. enhance the diversity
66. enhancing diversity
67. environmental quality
68. equal opportunity
69. equality
70. equitable
71. equitableness
72. equity
73. ethnicity
74. excluded
75. exclusion
76. expression
77. female
78. females
79. feminism
80. fostering inclusivity
81. GBV
82. gender
83. gender based
84. gender based violence
85. gender diversity
86. gender identity
87. gender ideology
88. gender-affirming care
89. genders
90. Gulf of Mexico
91. hate speech
92. health disparity
93. health equity
94. hispanic minority
95. historically
96. identity
97. immigrants
98. implicit bias
99. implicit biases
100. inclusion
101. inclusive
102. inclusive leadership
103. inclusiveness
104. inclusivity
105. increase diversity
106. increase the diversity
107. indigenous community
108. inequalities
109. inequality
110. inequitable
111. inequities
112. inequity
113. injustice
114. institutional
115. intersectional
116. intersectionality
117. key groups
118. key people
119. key populations
120. Latinx
121. LGBT
122. LGBTQ
123. marginalize
124. marginalized
125. men who have sex with men
126. mental health
127. minorities
128. minority
129. most risk
130. MSM
131. multicultural
132. Mx
133. Native American
134. non-binary
135. nonbinary
136. oppression
137. oppressive
138. orientation
139. people + uterus
140. people-centered care
141. person-centered
142. person-centered care
143. polarization
144. political
145. pollution
146. pregnant people
147. pregnant person
148. pregnant persons
149. prejudice
150. privilege



151. privileges
152. promote diversity
153. promoting diversity
154. pronoun
155. pronouns
156. prostitute
157. race
158. race and ethnicity
159. racial
160. racial diversity
161. racial identity
162. racial inequality
163. racial justice
164. racially
165. racism
166. segregation
167. sense of belonging
168. sex
169. sexual preferences
170. sexuality
171. social justice
172. sociocultural
173. socioeconomic
174. status
175. stereotype
176. stereotypes
177. systemic
178. systemically
179. they/them
180. trans
181. transgender
182. transsexual
183. trauma
184. traumatic
185. tribal
186. unconscious bias
187. underappreciated
188. underprivileged
189. underrepresentation
190. underrepresented
191. underserved
192. undervalued
193. victim
194. victims
195. vulnerable populations
196. women
197. women and underrepresented

Symbolic can be seen as one of the way of being represented. To have the possibility to retrace histories of communities, understanding how and figure out what happened in various historical and social perspectives in order to produce new knowledge. By producing knowledge, I mean here the faculty and potentiality of creating critical content on what we are experiencing as communities. Create the possibility to reflect on intersectionality, whether it takes place in articles, research, art practices, but also referred to media or websites, hence the importance of Stonewall monument website.

Going back to Eco's writing, he quotes:

« Ionesco once said that “only words count and the rest is mere chattering.” Linguistic habits are frequently important symptoms of underlying feelings. »

I think this underlines the necessity of words and that erasing vocabulary is far from a naive action. If some people control what we can say, it is a door open to all sort of obscure manoeuvring, where repressed people can not anymore catch the concern from what or who they are oppressed by.

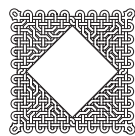
There is a gap, a lack of possibilities left to grasp. If transgender people cannot anymore refer to what they are as a community, where the stance of words is primordial, then begins a slow cancelation of our being, and becomings.



This enlightens the apparatus of fascism as a strategy to take control of by blurring our sense of self. It is at the same time a matter of individuality by recognising ourselves, but also as a community, finding with whom to stand with to be understood. Being understood to unlock collectively the potential to claim our acceptance in a threatening political climate. Ionesco refers to feelings too, which seems obvious: without the capacity to express in words or various semiotics what we are going through, then we miss the possibility to understand what we are facing.



On the White House's website, there is a quote of Donald Trump saying: « We will terminate every diversity, equity, and inclusion program across the entire federal government. »⁹ The fact that he uses the term « terminate » enhances his fascist apparatus through the war vocabulary, so dear to fascist leaders. Going back to Ur-Fascism, we can clearly relate this strategy to Eco's Point 12: « Since both permanent war and heroism are difficult games to play, the Ur-Fascist transfers his will to power to sexual matters. This is the origin of machismo (which implies both disdain for women and intolerance and condemnation of nonstandard sexual habits, from chastity to homosexuality). Since even sex is a difficult game to play, the Ur-Fascist hero tends to play with weapons... »¹⁰



WCCO NEWS 11 AM
WCCO NEWS

It is quite alarming how anti-LGBTQIA+ policy within Trump Administration and his vocabulary employment seem to be a pure example of what Umberto Eco points out here; how limp the connection can easily be done.

I would like to go back to this idea of the Fear of Difference, as to know, creating another group in order to affirm a form of supremacy, enhances a feeling of belonging to something pure. If federal administrations in the United States and US private enterprises (like Walmart and Facebook have already applied to their policies) in few years have completed this DEI obliteration, the tools left to minorities to be included in this capitalist system will be meaningless.

But it is also showing the irrationality of a fascist semantic governance: in order to apply DEI executive order, Donald Trump is also claiming for the « inclusion » of white straight men, which reveals the incompatibility of his own saying. Despite what he is claiming, he is creating a relatable form of « inclusion » to his own group (however there is really no need to), but that also reveals how fascists can adopt a language of equity and inclusion.

Marsha P. Johnson, 1969



Sources

1. Roland Barthes, *Mythologies* (Paris: Seuil, 1957).
2. Victor Klemperer, *LTI: Lingua Tertii Imperii* (Berlin: Aufbau Verlag, 1947).
3. Jacques Derrida, *Archive Fever: A Freudian Impression*, trans. Eric Prenowitz (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996).
4. Achille Mbembe, *Necropolitics*, trans. Steven Corcoran (Durham: Duke University Press, 2019).
5. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, trans. Robert Hurley, Mark Seem, and Helen R. Lane (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1983).
6. Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London: Verso, 1983).
7. Derek Gregory, *The Colonial Present: Afghanistan, Palestine, Iraq* (Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishing, 2004).
8. Amnesty International, "Morocco/Western Sahara: Authorities Must End Harassment of Journalists," Amnesty International Reports (various years). Human Rights Watch, "Morocco: Journalists Jailed After Unfair Trials," HRW Reports (various years).
9. Amnesty International & Forbidden Stories, *The Pegasus Project* (2021), investigative reporting on the use of Pegasus spyware.
10. U.S. Department of State, "Proclamation on Recognizing the Sovereignty of the Kingdom of Morocco over the Western Sahara," December 10, 2020.

Font used: Alte Haas Grotesk by Yann Le Coroller

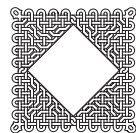
Redacted Redacted Redacted: Language, Territory, and the Self

Redaction as a Semiotic Regime

Both previous texts point to the same idea: fascism is a political structure that emerges from and is supported by a semiotic operation. In this text, i focus on how the fascist machine governs meaning, visibility, and therefore shaping reality itself. By erasing words, territories, and identities until only one “authorised meaning”¹ remains. This is the mechanism through which fascism narrows the field of what can be said, seen and known, gradually molding a new reality in its own image.

[REDACTED] ([REDACTED],
[REDACTED], [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]) [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]: [REDACTED],
[REDACTED],
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]. [REDACTED]
[REDACTED], [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]; [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED].

Redaction (be it linguistic, cartographic, or bureaucratic) is not simply a technique of concealment but a way of organising subjects and territories by controlling the very conditions of legibility: who may speak and what may be articulated. In this sense, redaction is not an exception within fascist practice; it is the paradigm through which fascist power operates.



The semiotic dimension of fascism becomes clearest when examining how states and institutions approach visibility. Fascist language, as Victor Klemperer observed, works by reducing complexity, eliminating nuance, and replacing lived experience with rigid categories.²

When vocabulary is restricted,

so too is the horizon of the imagination.

Ambiguity becomes suspect,

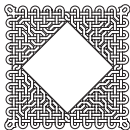
and the world is divided into binaries.



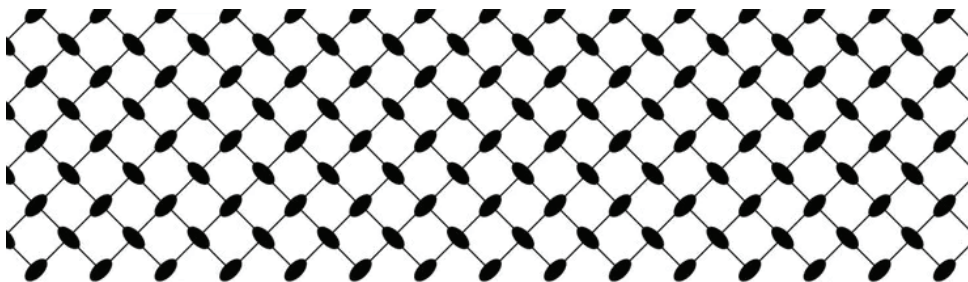
Rep. Thomas Massie, R-W.Va., questions Attorney General Pam Bondi as she testifies before a House Judiciary Committee oversight hearing.

Epst=ein

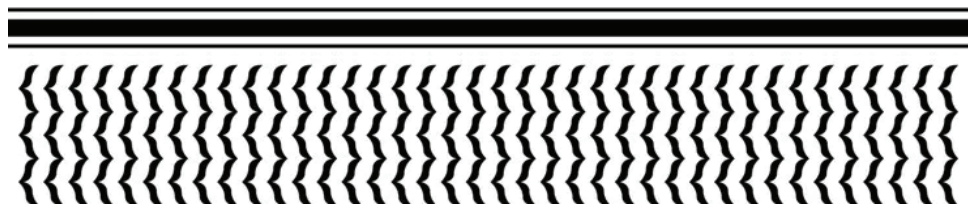
What contemporary example illustrates this better than the Epstein files? When the Department of Justice released the documents in compliance with the Epstein Files Transparency Act, they were fragmented, heavily blacked-out and strategically curated. The redactions became the message. Entire pages were reduced to black rectangles, a visual grammar of secrecy that communicated power precisely through what it withheld. The public was invited to witness the archive while being strategically prohibited from accessing its meaning.



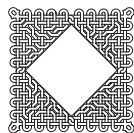
Derrida reminds us that the archive is always structured by secrecy, and that power is exercised through the management of what is visible.³ Achille Mbembe's notion of "the aesthetics of opacity" further clarifies how states use selective visibility to maintain authority.⁴ The Epstein files exemplify this notion: names and faces surface only to vanish again, connections are suggested but never confirmed, the architecture of elite networks is glimpsed only through the gaps in the text. We stand before the document as Kafka's man before the gate of the Law,



summoned to look, condemned to wait and disciplined by uncertainty. The redaction is not a veil over truth; it is the truth the state offers, a managed opacity that asserts authority by controlling the conditions of legibility.



Among the many names that flicker in and out of visibility in these documents are officials from multiple countries. To appear and then be redacted is not to be absolved, it is to be held in a permanent state of managed suspicion, useful to power precisely because nothing is confirmed and nothing is denied. This is not a failure of the archive; it is its function. The selective visibility of these names mirrors a broader global pattern.

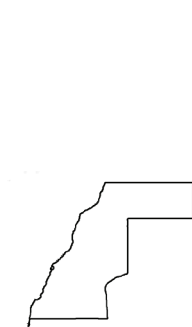


The Epstein files do not reveal a network. They reveal the shape of a network, its silhouette, traced in black. We are given the experience of almost-knowing. An archive of permanent almost-disclosure keeps the public suspended in anticipatory attention, never able to look away, never able to arrive. Deleuze and Guattari describe capitalism as a system that “decodes flows” (of labor, desire, money).⁵

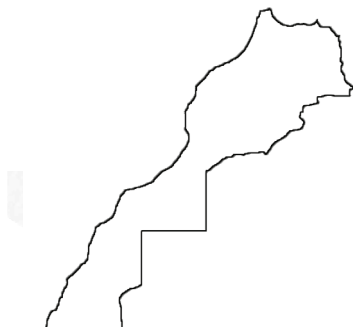
Fascism emerges as a reaction to this instability, it recodes these flows into fixed identities of race, nation, and destiny. Capitalism isolates, fascism promises belonging through exclusion. Redaction becomes the technique through which this recoding is enforced: a way of simplifying the world until it fits the contours of a power-hungry imaginary.

Morocco

The cartographic redaction of Western Sahara is another example that comes to mind. Maps are not neutral representations; they are instruments of national myth-making. Benedict Anderson famously argued that nations are imagined through maps, censuses, and museums.⁶ Derek Gregory’s work on colonial cartography shows how maps function as tools of territorial authority.⁷ Morocco’s insistence on including Western Sahara within its borders, and the social hostility toward maps that do not is a form of semiotic policing. The territory is not merely claimed; it is rendered unthinkable as anything other than Moroccan.



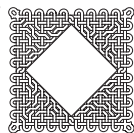
Western
Sahara



Morocco with the occupied
territory attached



Morocco without the
occupied territory

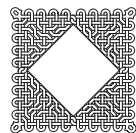


To draw a different map is to commit a political offense. Journalists such as Omar Radi, Soulaïman Raïssouni, and Hajar Raïssouni were each, in different ways, documenting what the cartographic consensus sought to erase: the lived reality of Western Sahara, the voices of those whose existence the authorised map renders invisible. Their imprisonment is not incidental to the map; it is its enforcement mechanism. The black bar over Western Sahara and the prison cell occupy the same political logic — both are techniques for ensuring that an unauthorised reality cannot circulate. This cartographic redaction is reinforced by the criminalisation of speech. Journalists such as Omar Radi and Soulaïman and Hajar Raïssouni have been imprisoned on charges widely criticised by Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch as politically motivated.⁸ Their cases illustrate how the state polices not only territory but discourse. Allowing a different narrative about Western Sahara is met with arrest. The semiotic field is narrowed through legal and extralegal means, ensuring that only authorised narratives circulate.

Surveillance deepens this regime of control. Morocco has been linked to the use of Pegasus spyware, a tool capable of infiltrating smartphones and extracting messages, contacts, and recordings.⁹ Surveillance is not merely a technical practice; it is a semiotic one. It produces a climate of self-censorship, where individuals internalise the gaze of the state and regulate their own speech. The pegasus panopticon extends into the intimate spaces of digital life.



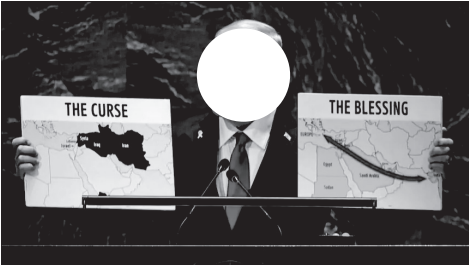
Prime Minister B***** N***** holds up a map of the Middle East and North Africa during a TV interview, May 30, 2024.



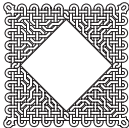
The recent Gen-Z protests in Morocco expose the fragility of this semiotic regime. A generation raised online, fluent in irony and hyper-visibility, has begun to articulate grievances that the state has long attempted to suppress: unemployment, corruption, repression, and the suffocating limits placed on political expression. Their slogans, memes, and livestreams form an insurgency, a refusal to inhabit the state's authorised vocabulary. In circulating alternative narratives, they reclaim the power to name reality on their own terms.

The state responds with arrests and surveillance. This reveals a political order that does not negotiate meaning but imposes it.

The contrast with the Epstein case is instructive here. In the United States, redaction is performed through the archive: documents are released, but legibility is withheld.



Prime Minister B***** N***** holding signs as he addresses the 79th session of the UN General Assembly, September 27, 2024.



An aerial view of the sand wall that runs through southeastern Morocco and the Western Sahara taken en route from the Polisario Front's Rabouni camp near Tindouf, Algeria to the Bir Lahlou site of the United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara (MINURSO).



Credit: UN Photo/Evan Schneider

The performance of transparency substitutes for transparency itself. In Morocco, the performance is dispensed with entirely: speech is not obscured, it is criminalised. Both are techniques of semiotic control, but they address different political constituencies. Liberal democracies manage meaning through excess and fragmentation; authoritarian states manage it through prohibition and silence. The architecture differs but the function is the same. Unlike liberal democracies, where legitimacy is at least formally constructed through a two-way exchange between state and citizen, Morocco's communicative architecture is fundamentally vertical. Meaning flows downward, not across. The government does not merely regulate discourse; it monopolises it. The result is a domineering semiotic environment in which citizens are expected to inhabit a single, state-produced reality, and any deviation is treated as a threat to territorial integrity, national unity and public order. This is a semiotic absolutism, a world in which the state claims exclusive rights over what counts as truth.



Politics of Meaning

What the Epstein files and the Moroccan semiotic regime share is not merely opacity but its political productivity. In both cases, the state deploys hiddenness as a form of governance. This domestic logic of managed legibility scales upward: geopolitical alliances are themselves structured by agreements about what will and will not be made visible.

These domestic dynamics intersect with geopolitical ones. In 2020, the United States recognised Moroccan sovereignty over Western Sahara as part of a diplomatic exchange in which Morocco normalised relations with Israel.¹⁰ Geopolitical alliances determine which redactions are tolerated and by whom. The architecture of secrecy is never local.

What the Gen-Z protesters in Morocco understand, and what the Epstein archive inadvertently demonstrates, is that the silhouette of a thing is still information.

You can read a territory by what the map refuses to name.

Fascism thrives on opacity, on the narrowing of meaning, on the reduction of complexity to authorised simplicity.

Un-redacted politics must do the opposite: cultivate ambiguity, embrace plurality and insist on the right to name reality in all its contradictions.





Sources

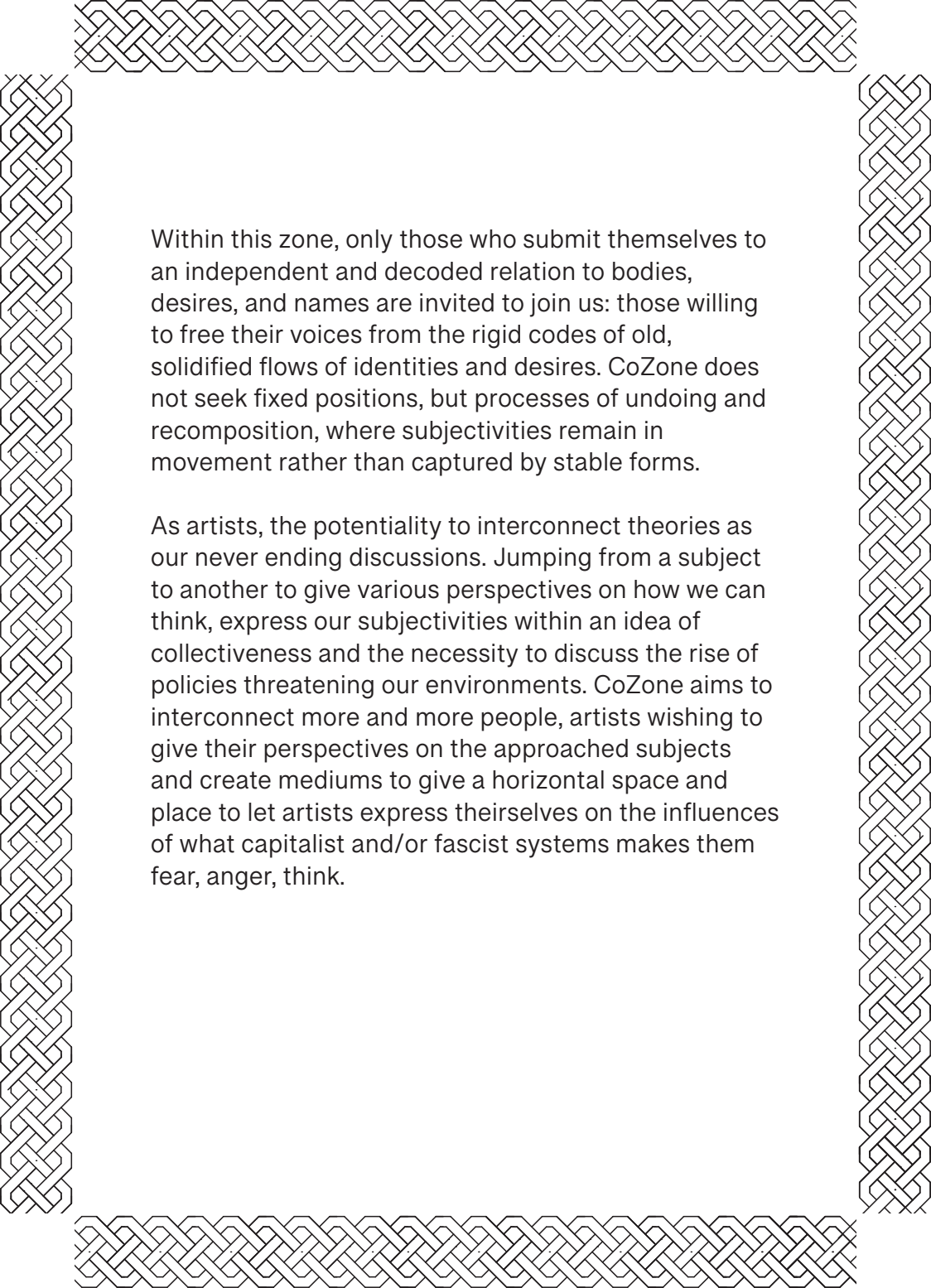
1. Parnell, S. « Memorandum for Senior Pentagon Leadership Commanders of the Combatant Commands Defense Agency and Dod 1 Field Activity Directors », Digital Content Refresh, Department of Defense, Public Affairs, Pentagon, Washington D.C, 26th February 2025.
2. « Details about Trump's executive orders around DEI are causing confusion », Haya Panjwani, Associated Press, February 21, 2025.
3. « Growing number of federal health agencies are combing grants for taboo words, unnerving researchers », Usha Lee McFarling, 3 Angus Chen, and Sarah Oweremohle, STAT10, Feb. 13, 2025.
4. Eco, U. Ur Fascism, The New York Reviews of Book, 22th June 1995, United States.
5. Ibid.
6. Olson, A. & Miller, Z.« Trump administration directs all federal diversity, equity and inclusion staff be put on leave », January 22, 2025, Associated Press, United States.
7. Eco, U. Ur Fascism, The New York Reviews of Book, 22th June 1995, United States.
8. Ubadhyay, B. « Transgender references removed from Stonewall monument website », BBC News, Washington, 14th February 2025.
9. <https://www.whitehouse.gov/fact-sheets/2025/03/fact-sheet-president-donald-j-trump-removes-dei-from-the-foreign-service/>
10. Eco, U. Ur Fascism, The New York Reviews of Book, 22th June 1995, United States.

Font used: BBB Baskervvol by Bye Bye Binary

Kaz Mose (it/they) is an independant filmmaker based in Brussels, born in Tehran. In its writings and works, Kaz researched and wrote about subjects such as "Revolution and Kairos", "Schizoanalysis", "Post-media and the Body" and "Haecceity and Identity". They have experience with film directing, political "inter-activism", literary writing, film montage, treasure hunting and freelance ghost catching.

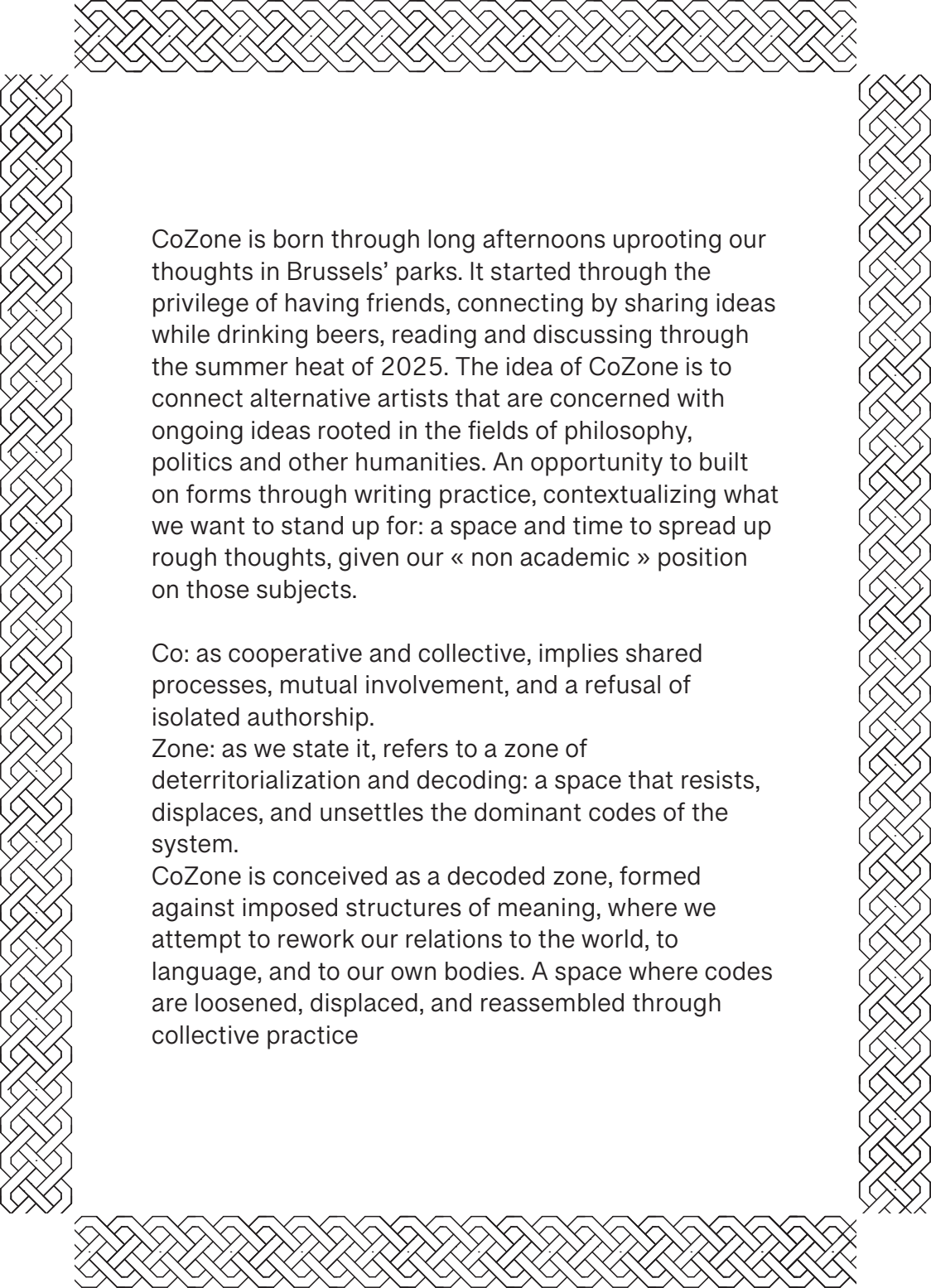
Azur Schleinitz is an artist, working with film, writings and installations based in Brussels. His work deals with political questions of perception, subjective positions through biotopes and queerness. Focusing on where humand beings in natural societal contexts evolve, between poetry and facts, sciences and philosophy. His artistic practice tries to formulate questions through plural voices and his own on these subjects.

oumaima (she/ they) is a moroccan filmmaker, writer, designer and developper based in Brussels. My work explores language in multiple registers, typographic (the shape of a letter), literary (the weight of a word), and computational (the logic of a machine.). Currently focusing on the politics of borders, the aesthetics of bureaucracy, and the question of migration/displacement.



Within this zone, only those who submit themselves to an independent and decoded relation to bodies, desires, and names are invited to join us: those willing to free their voices from the rigid codes of old, solidified flows of identities and desires. CoZone does not seek fixed positions, but processes of undoing and recomposition, where subjectivities remain in movement rather than captured by stable forms.

As artists, the potentiality to interconnect theories as our never ending discussions. Jumping from a subject to another to give various perspectives on how we can think, express our subjectivities within an idea of collectiveness and the necessity to discuss the rise of policies threatening our environments. CoZone aims to interconnect more and more people, artists wishing to give their perspectives on the approached subjects and create mediums to give a horizontal space and place to let artists express themselves on the influences of what capitalist and/or fascist systems makes them fear, anger, think.



CoZone is born through long afternoons uprooting our thoughts in Brussels' parks. It started through the privilege of having friends, connecting by sharing ideas while drinking beers, reading and discussing through the summer heat of 2025. The idea of CoZone is to connect alternative artists that are concerned with ongoing ideas rooted in the fields of philosophy, politics and other humanities. An opportunity to built on forms through writing practice, contextualizing what we want to stand up for: a space and time to spread up rough thoughts, given our « non academic » position on those subjects.

Co: as cooperative and collective, implies shared processes, mutual involvement, and a refusal of isolated authorship.

Zone: as we state it, refers to a zone of deterritorialization and decoding: a space that resists, displaces, and unsettles the dominant codes of the system.

CoZone is conceived as a decoded zone, formed against imposed structures of meaning, where we attempt to rework our relations to the world, to language, and to our own bodies. A space where codes are loosened, displaced, and reassembled through collective practice

		1	4			6	9	
	6	7	2	3		1	4	
	4	3	1		6		2	5
	8	6				4	3	
7				1		2	6	9
				6		8		
3					7	5		
					1		7	
6	7	8	5	2		3	1	4

